

ETHICS II

III. THE DESIRE FOR HAPPINESS AND THE MORAL LIFE

Theme 6. Desire for happiness and morality.

- Everyone wants to be happy; however, the problems come when we try to define what happiness is made of.
 - o We have all experienced the fact that after taking a decision that we thought would make us happy, we have not actually attained that happiness (watch a movie, get a particular type of job).
 - o So we can say that the content of happiness is not self evident to us.
 - o Ethics involves defining happiness and how to achieve it.
- When we discussed the first dimension of freedom, fundamental freedom, we commented that it permits us to develop our own life project.
 - o However, we have to ask ourselves, what is the goal we are seeking in this life project; we are free to make our lives, but what is the goal that we want to reach in our lives?
 - o We may have high targets we want to achieve; we may even consider them to be the ideals which shape and give meaning to our lives; for example, perhaps we want to become Managing Director of Microsoft Kenya, to reach the same post in the global company, to own the company ourselves, and then what?
 - o What are we ultimately seeking through the struggle to achieve those targets, make those ideals a reality in our lives?
 - o In the long term, the overall, absolute goal we are seeking is that of a happy life; everything that we want or desire to achieve as persons goes back ultimately to that desire for a happy life.
 - o So we can say that the final goal that we all seek in a natural and necessary way, is that of a happy life¹.

¹ Cf. YEPES STORK, R., *Fundamentos de antropología*, Eunsu, Pamplona 1996, p.173.

- This final goal (in general terms) is not just a future target, it is the root of all our desires, and it is our reference point when seeking what is good for us; it is the reason for which we desire and choose everything else.
 - Specifically, this final goal which orients all our decisions is the desire for a happy life; we all necessarily seek that goal, due to the way we have been made and yet, we are free to choose the ways of going about achieving that aim.
 - So ethical experience is actually made up of our need to be happy and our capacity to freely choose how to attain that happiness.
 - However, the desire to be happy is general, it is not fully satisfied by the free choice of one specific thing, be it material or spiritual.
 - As a result, we are free to choose among many possible sources of happiness; there is not just one thing that, if freely chosen, will give perfect and definitive happiness.
 - This experience leads us to realize that this general desire to be happy needs to be concretized, made more specific, by freely deciding on and choosing the particular type of life and behaviour, which we consider the most appropriate for attaining happiness².
 - This brings us to the issue of discovering what is the content of happiness; which life style will actually lead us towards attaining final and definitive happiness, with no trace of evil.

The content of happiness

- Each person must freely decide for himself what he considers to be most important in order to be happy, although he may be mistaken in his choice; the great problem for each person lies precisely in discovering where absolute happiness is to be found.
 - Any good thing produces a certain happiness, however we have to see if any good thing exists which can totally satisfy our desire for happiness.
 - § St. Thomas Aquinas developed a list of the different good things in which man can seek happiness; see it in *Summa theologiae* I-II, q. 94, a. 2. Here we will deal with it in a summary form.
 - Material riches, or wealth: a certain amount of material goods are necessary to cover the human being's needs, however, they are subordinated to his overall dignity as a person, which goes beyond his material needs.

² Cf. RODRIGUEZ LUNO, A, *Ética general*, Eunsa, Pamplona 1991, p. 192.

- § For this reason, it would be ridiculous to seek them for their own sake; everyone can experience the fact that, owning these goods is only a means in order to be happy but they don't make us happy in themselves.
- Bodily goods (health): neither does this form of good make us totally happy, because the person is not only body, we are also spiritual beings and so we need more than just bodily health to make us completely happy.
 - § This may also be seen in the fact that people who do not possess bodily health can still be happy and are happy.
- Spiritual goods (virtues, wisdom): full happiness is not to be found either in spiritual goods, because as we have a spiritual soul by our nature, we should be happy from the first moment of our existence; experience shows that this is not the case, hence we can say that the possession of spiritual goods does not satisfy our desire for happiness.
- Pleasure (mixture of spiritual and bodily goods): hedonism states that the sum total of different types of pleasure would be the source of perfect happiness; however, the human being has been made for a real and objective good which goes beyond the subjective desire for satisfaction in pleasure.
 - § In fact, experience also shows that the person who seeks happiness only in pleasure and giving into the various passions, doesn't find perfect happiness there and ends up being the slave of his instincts.
 - § This is because, the seeking of happiness only in pleasure brings us to abandon the use of reason and so, to be less human in our free choices.
- Power: one can also seek happiness in the degree of power over others and things that may be attained through one's profession or in political activity; once a person achieves the power they seek, they also find that it is not enough to fill the desire for absolute happiness which lies in the human heart.
- Obviously, anything good produces a certain happiness when obtained; however happiness itself does not consist in owning riches, honour, fame, power, virtues, etc. because all these things are only means to achieve something which is beyond them: perfect and absolute happiness.
 - Although we are finite creatures, we have been made with an infinite desire for happiness which cannot be satisfied by anything finite, any creature; we naturally desire a perfect and absolute happiness which can only be fully satisfied by obtaining as our own the infinite, absolute, Supreme Being Himself.

- The object of our desire for happiness goes beyond the human person himself; the happy life we are seeking is not finite but infinite; hence it cannot be sought in the created world, but only in the Creator, the Supreme Being.
 - Only God, the Supreme Being, is the greatest and most perfect Good; hence, only the possession of God will join us to the perfect good which we seek as the source of our absolute happiness and which will satisfy our infinite desire for happiness.
 - This is because what we basically desire is to be permanently happy in a stable way, enjoying all the possible good things; this is only possible if we share in the infinity of the Supreme Good who is God Himself.
- We can also understand that man's happiness lies in sharing in the infinite life of the Supreme Being if we consider that created goods cannot satisfy our infinite desire for happiness precisely because they can be lost or destroyed; our happiness would not be perfect if it is marred by the possibility of losing the goods that we are enjoying.
 - The only good that can make man fully happy is one that is spiritual (immaterial and not destroyable) and infinite (everlasting): the only spiritual and infinite good that exists is God Himself.
 - The only good thing that can make a human person entirely happy is the possession of God, enjoy God, because He is the incorruptible, eternal, spiritual and infinite good that fully satisfies the desires of the human heart.
- As man is free, he can reject God and seek his happiness in other finite goods; if he does so, he will not find true happiness and he will also be living beneath his dignity as a human person because he will be seeking in created goods a satisfaction that they do not have the capacity to give him.
 - He may satisfy some of his desires, but will not satisfy his longing for perfect and infinite happiness.
 - The person who puts his happiness in something which is not the final goal does not enjoy his true end and so, cannot be completely happy.
- Hence, we can see that it is possible to distinguish between the objective last goal of man according to the way he has been created, and that is sharing in the happiness of God Himself, and the subjective final goal, that which the person freely chooses for himself .

- o Subjectively speaking, the person can choose different created goods as his final goal, however, keeping in mind that which objectively is the final goal which will fully satisfy him, God Himself who is the Perfect Goodness that makes the other created goods exist and attractive to us, the subjective goal chosen will not make the person fully happy.
- o The objective final goal exists which will give us absolute happiness, God Himself.
- o Each person must choose his own subjective last goal; if he chooses God, the objective final goal, he will be perfectly happy; if he chooses his final goal outside God, he will not be fully happy.
- o Now we need to consider how man can choose the objective final goal as his own personal subjective last goal.

The practical determining of the content of happiness

- Every human being has the natural inclination to seek happiness; however, this does not mean that we automatically know what is the good thing that will make us totally happy.
 - o As we have intellect and will, we have to discover with the intellect, get to know and understand what is good.
 - o The intellect presents this good known thing to the will and the will freely desires/ aims at attaining this good thing.
 - o Hence the will moves itself and all the other faculties of the person to act in order to obtain this good thing.
- Here we will study in a bit more detail how this process occurs; how we determine the content of the happiness we are seeking.
- The human will has a natural tendency to seek good things, in order to achieve happiness through them; this tendency is so natural to us that it cannot be avoided, nor impeded; it is a capacity of our will which forms part of our makeup; being a potency or a capacity, it is undetermined, it is general and is known as the “voluntas ut natura”.
- This capacity can be actualized when the human being through the will, determines himself to desire or tend towards obtaining a particular and specific good thing.

- o This is possible because the good thing has been known by the intellect and presented to the will, by the intellect, as good; so the will tend towards this specific good thing for a reason => this aspect of the will's activity is known as "voluntas ut ratio".
 - o The will is determined to desire a particular thing, by a choice, which was based on knowledge of the good thing; it was understood to be a source of happiness.
- There may be an error in the way the desired thing has been known:
 - o When the intellect presents the good thing to the will as an absolute good, when it is not really so .
 - o Experience can also show that a known good that was freely chosen does not bring the expected happiness, because it was not capable of doing so; the intellect had known or understood the thing incorrectly.
- The human being needs to discover what happiness really consists of.
 - o He can discover that it may only be achieved in an infinite good thing.
 - o Because finite goods prove themselves to be unsatisfactory to the will, which has an infinite potency for happiness and is never fully satisfied with created goods.
 - o "The natural tendency to happiness would be frustrated if there did not exist, or the intellect did not find anything more than finite goods. But at the moment when the will enters into contact with the intellect (voluntas ut ratio), the good will be presented as finite, and as such, unsatisfactory to the will, which is an infinite potency. So, although it is true that we only love that which we know, the knowledge of the good ought to grow"³.
 - o Man, therefore, needs to get to know the true good better.
- As the will is a spiritual potency with an infinite desire for and capacity for happiness, it will only be fully and perfectly happy when it desires, tends towards and possesses the infinite and absolute Good; that is: God.
 - o The intellect can discover and know this fact, but our natural tendency to happiness (voluntas ut natura), does not know this, so it won't seek God directly.
 - o Rather, the intellect needs to deepen in it's knowledge of God and present the truth about God to the will as the supreme Good (because the intellect has understood that this is so):

³ POLO, L., *Ética: hacia una versión moderna de los temas clásicos*, Colección AEDOS, Unión Editorial, Madrid 1997, p. 140.

- o Then the will can discover that God is really the supreme Good, accept this, and seek God, tend towards God as the supreme source of absolute and perfect happiness.
 - o We need to get to know God better and better, so that we can discover his attractiveness, and so seek to love Him more and more.
- In synthesis, the will naturally tends towards happiness in an infinite way (it is an infinite capacity for ever greater happiness).
 - o True happiness and everlasting (infinite) happiness is only to be found in the Infinite Good.
 - o The will actually chooses the Infinite Good (God), only if the intellect knows and understands that God is the Infinite Good; the intellect must show to the will the excellence of God, so that the will tends towards God as it's Supreme Good, and final goal, here and now.
 - o Knowledge of God and His Goodness is not directly evident to us (self evident), because God is pure spirit and we are finite, and bodily as well as spiritual creatures; so we need to learn to know God and discover His excellence, His Goodness.
- So the will is open to perfect happiness, but it cannot tends towards this happiness without the help of the intellect.
 - o The will is one faculty but it has two different “moments” or “situations”.
 - o Voluntas ut natura: the will as a passive potency that is determined by the natural desire for happiness.
 - o Voluntas ut ratio: the will actualized by reason so that the capacity to desire a particular good as a source of happiness is set in motion, as the subjective final goal (final goal of the desiring subject).

Attaining happiness

- We have seen that, objectively, the final goal of man is sharing in the happy life of God (objective final goal).
- This goal needs to become the subjective final goal (aim of the individual person), by being “taken on”, or freely accepted, by the person.
 - o This requires effort: that of the intellect to know what is truly good; that of the will to choose that true good.

- o This effort is made continuously in our specific decisions and acts each day; these manifest our idea of what a truly happy life is like.
- All this means that the person is the author, or maker, of his own life; he is constantly judging his own free acts in terms of the final goal he wants to achieve.
- o We can see that reaching or attaining happiness is a goal, a target and a task that involves the free effort of the person concerned.
 - o As a consequence, the person grows, develops and becomes a more perfect, a better person through the constant effort of using his intellect, will and all his other capacities well.
- The free efforts of the person, which will make him better, will be good if they are coherent with what is truly good for man (corresponds to the true final goal); then, the acts will express the free orientation of the person to his final goal.
- o And the fact that he has made the objective final goal of man into his own personal, subjective final goal.
- The human being is capable of and should develop freely through his acts; however, he needs help so as to adapt his free acts to the real goal.
- o This is the role of reason: to know or discover the conformity or not of the person's acts to the true goal.
 - o The human intellect should discover and set goals for human activity, and guide that activity towards those goals.
- For these free human acts to bring man closer to true happiness, the object of the act must be coherent with the final goal, that is, with the truth about God and also about man.
- o The truth about man, about the human being, about human nature is a reference point for the intellect when considering the goodness of the acts that it will present to the free will as desirable.
 - o The person's acts will be good and will bring him closer to true happiness, if those acts are in accord with, agree with the truth about human nature, about man.
 - o As the human being is rational, he can think and know the truth, his acts must be rational, and they must respect and reflect the truth.
 - o Man's acts will be morally good if they are based on the objective truth about that which is good, in as much as the human person can know it.

- We now need to study the objective moral order; that is, what man can know about right and wrong based on the truth about the world.